

IROKO-BOT Impact statement

Nigeria's health system, including its mental health provision, has long been underfunded. More than 90% of Nigerians have no health insurance, and now face uncertainty over access to services and feelings of helplessness over rising costs. Iroko-Bot, a medical chatbot that serves primarily as a means of stigma free emotional connection, validation and advice, also as a source of Medical information and advice on Mental health to create awareness of certain mental illness and enlighten its users on the symptoms, propose drug free remedies that can ease the ailment and also propose the need to see a medical professional if the need arises.

Iroko-bot will serve as an easy access for users to engage in discussions that can ease their mental health burdens, and reduce the cost of having to see a professional more frequently than needed. It will also serve as a tool to ease loneliness and also provide the platform to share private information without the stigma that comes with it.

We do not intend that the chat bot replaces professional help and diagnosis, we fear that users will take the responses of the chatbot as true always without having to verify the information themselves or seek clarification with other humans and professionals. We also fear that the bot will be used for medical diagnosis and treatment prescription which it was not primarily designed for.

However, our project seeks to create more awareness on mental health, which is needed in the Nigerian community. Many basic mental health problems in Nigeria are usually diagnosed as something else. We hope to see Nigerians speaking up about their Mental health concerns, not accepting the false truths that have been placed in front of them. We also hope that they find it easy to express how they feel to Iroko-Bot and find it convenient to share the things that weigh them down

We have ensured that the datasets are tailored to the Nigerian community's needs, such that the referral links provided for medical professionals are in Nigeria, to ensure that severe cases are handled properly. We also considered a lot of adversarial prompts to help the model handle cases which are not common, we truly hope the model handles what comes its way accordingly. We intend to add a disclaimer to the chat bot responses and the UI on which it is served.

We fear that the model might not sound as humanly possible and fail to capture severe cases appropriately.